

# Workstation Migration

## Bringing the Operator's Own Machine Into the Threat Model

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Prepared 2026-06-04 (rev. 2).

### 1 What this document is

This is the story of the most recent milestone, which took the machine I administer the whole system from and rebuilt it to the same standard as everything it administers. I am giving it its own document because the reasoning is the interesting part, and because it is the clearest example in the project of a residual risk I named in writing and then went back to close. As with every other document here, the parts list is deliberately out: the distribution, the desktop, the terminal and shell environment, the editor, the bootloader, and the encryption layout are not named. What is in is the reasoning, the discipline, and an honest account of what the migration closes and what it leaves open.

### 2 The machine I had not thought about

For most of this project I hardened everything except the thing I was hardening it from. The infrastructure got a threat model, an audit, traceable findings, and two hardening passes. The workstation got none of that. It was a mainstream consumer operating system with a compatibility layer bolted on top to run the Linux tooling, and it was the single most-privileged endpoint in the environment: it held the keys, ran the administrative sessions, and could reach every other machine, while carrying the entire opaque attack surface of a closed consumer OS plus the seams of the shim stitched onto it.

The threat model document is honest about this. The “admin-workstation compromise” row in the residual-risk section has been there since the first version, and for a long time the only mitigations I could write in that row were partial ones. A fortress run from a soft machine is not a fortress; it is a soft machine with good intentions about the network behind it. This milestone exists because I got tired of the gap between how carefully I treated the servers and how casually I treated the laptop in front of them.

### 3 Bringing the threat model to the workstation

The goal was not a prettier desktop. The goal was to move the “admin-workstation compromise” row from mostly-unmitigated toward bounded, and to do it with the same discipline the rest of the project uses. Three changes carry most of the weight.

The first is that the workstation no longer holds the keys to the kingdom. Fleet access now rests on a short-lived signed certificate issued by a private certificate authority, not on long-lived per-host keys that sit on the disk indefinitely. A credential lifted off the machine ages out on its own, and a single central action revokes it for everything at once. The blast radius of a workstation

compromise is now the remaining lifetime of one short certificate, not the indefinite life of a pile of static keys.

The second is that the secrets were never on the machine to begin with. The actual credentials live in the vault, behind a second factor, and the workstation reaches them through gated access rather than caching them locally. Owning the machine does not hand an attacker the vault.

The third is the one this whole milestone is about: the machine itself was rebuilt to the same hardened standard as the infrastructure, on a native, minimal platform with full-disk encryption, rather than continuing to administer a fortress from a consumer box chosen for convenience. The most-privileged endpoint stopped being the least-examined one.

## 4 Non-destructive by design

I did not wipe the old environment, and that was a deliberate safety decision rather than a compromise. The new platform installs alongside the old one as a second boot entry; the old environment stays, reduced to exactly two jobs it is genuinely better at, gaming and one heavyweight development environment with no equivalent on the new platform, and is kept isolated from anything to do with fortress administration. Nothing that administers the fleet runs over there anymore.

The reason for keeping it rather than burning it down is the same reason every hardening phase in this project keeps a rollback path: the daily driver is itself production now, and a migration that leaves no way back is a migration that turns one bad afternoon into a week of recovery. The old environment is the rollback path. Booting it bare produces a games machine and an IDE, nothing more, and that is the whole point.

## 5 The configuration is the artifact

The entire workstation configuration is captured as a single reproducible kit that can rebuild the machine from a clean install deterministically. This is not a tidiness preference; it is the disaster-recovery story. A workstation you can only rebuild by remembering what you did to it over six months is a workstation you cannot actually rebuild. A workstation defined by a versioned, declarative configuration is one I can stand up again from bare metal in an afternoon, which means I can afford to treat the running machine as disposable.

That property also closes one of the lessons from earlier in the project. Configuration that lives only in a running machine's head, and never in version control, is exactly the kind of thing that drifts out from under your audits. Defining the workstation declaratively means the machine and its description are the same thing, and the description is in the same place I keep everything else I trust.

## 6 Reliability as a security property

A control you route around because it is annoying is a control you do not have. The same is true of a workstation: if the daily driver is flaky, I will quietly start doing administrative work from

somewhere less hardened to get my day done, and the careful posture rots from the inside. So the final piece of the milestone treats reliability as part of the security work, not separate from it.

The workstation now carries a manifest that declares each desktop component's expected role, its health check, its resource budget, and its rollback path. A validator reads the live state against that manifest. A constrained repair planner may take only pre-approved corrective actions. The user-session services are supervised so they come back when they fall over, and a pre-flight gate with a known-good visual baseline gives the machine a state to fall back to. The reasoning behind these is in the scripts document; what matters here is the intent. A daily driver earns the name only when it recovers from its own faults without me babysitting it, because a workstation I have to fight is a workstation I will eventually stop trusting, and stopping trusting it is how the soft-machine problem comes back.

The native install, the dual-boot safety path, the certificate-based access, the declarative configuration, and the self-healing layer are in place. The next phases build a terminal-native command center on top of all of it, a single keyboard-driven environment for running fleet operations from one place; that part is in progress rather than finished, and I would rather say so than imply a tidier ending than the one I have.

## 7 What this closes, and what it does not

This is a hardened workstation, not an air-gapped one, and the difference is the residual risk. The machine still talks to the internet and still administers the fleet, so a browser-level or operating-system-level compromise of the workstation still owns the operator session and the short-lived certificate it currently holds, for as long as that certificate lives. The short time-to-live bounds the window; it does not eliminate it. Anyone who tells you a daily-use, internet-connected administrative workstation is fully defended against its own compromise is selling something.

What the milestone genuinely changed is the shape of that residual risk. Before, a compromise of the workstation meant long-lived keys to everything and secrets cached on the disk, with the machine itself an unexamined consumer OS. Now it means a single short certificate that expires and can be revoked centrally, secrets that were never on the disk, and a machine built and supervised to the same standard as the servers. The honest next step is a hardware second-factor that has to be physically touched to authorize each privileged action, which would cut the residual window down to the moment of each action rather than the life of a certificate. That is future work and it is not deployed yet, so it sits in the residual-risk column of the threat model with a phase attached, which is the only place in this project a known gap is allowed to sit.

The portable lesson is the one I wish I had taken seriously a year earlier. The machine you operate from is part of the system you are defending, not a neutral window onto it. If you have a threat model, the workstation belongs inside it, and the day you write “admin-workstation compromise” into the residual-risk column is the day you have started owing yourself the work this document describes.